



MyGurukul

SACRED WISDOM — SATURDAY, FEBRUARY 14, 2026



SACRED TEXT

*guruṃ vā bāla-vṛddhau vā brāhmaṇaṃ vā bahu-śrutam |
ātātāyinam āyāntaṃ hanyād evāvicārayan ||
ātātāyinam āyāntam api vedānta-pāragam |
jighāṃsantaṃ jighāṃsīyān na tena brahmahā bhavet ||
nanu -
smṛtyor virodhe nyāyas tu balavān vyavahārataḥ |
artha-śāstrāt tu balavad dharma-śāstram iti sthitiḥ || [Yājñavalkya 2.21]*

— Bhagavadgītā-4comm with the commentaries of Śrīdhara, Madhusūdana, Viśvanātha and Baladeva, Chapter 1, Verse

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GURU'S INTERPRETATION

These verses, although not directly from the Bhagavad Gītā itself but quoted within commentaries, address a complex ethical dilemma: when is it justifiable to use violence, particularly against someone seemingly deserving of respect? The verses speak of slaying an aggressor, even one who is a teacher, a child, an elder, a learned Brahmin, or well-versed in the Vedas, if they approach with the intent to kill. The quote from Yājñavalkya Smṛiti further clarifies the hierarchy of ethical principles, stating that when there's conflict between legal codes (Smṛiti), practical considerations prevail. Moreover, dharma-shastra (moral law) holds more weight than artha-shastra (economic or political strategy).

The passage isn't advocating wanton violence. Instead, it delves into the principle of self-defense and the preservation of dharma. The “aggressor” (ātātāyinam) is someone who has crossed a line, posing an immediate threat to your life or well-being, or to the well-being of others. Striking first in aggression is never condoned, but defending oneself and others from imminent harm is presented as a justifiable act, even if it requires taking a life.

In modern life, this translates not literally to physical violence, but to standing up against injustice and protecting yourself and others from harm, whether physical, emotional, or spiritual. It compels you to discern when inaction becomes complicity. Imagine a situation where you witness bullying, discrimination, or abuse. The “aggressor” isn't necessarily wielding a weapon, but their actions are causing harm. Do you remain silent, or do you intervene, risking potential discomfort or even personal repercussions? The wisdom here suggests that defending dharma – that which upholds righteousness and well-being – sometimes requires difficult choices and courageous action. It's about discerning when to turn the other cheek and when to draw a line in the sand, always prioritizing the protection of innocence and the upholding of ethical principles. It calls you to examine your own boundaries and your willingness to defend what is right, even when it's uncomfortable.

REFLECTION FOR TODAY

Are there situations in your life where you have remained silent in the face of injustice, and how can you find the courage to speak up and act in accordance with your dharma in the future?